



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

upavāsa+vidhīn na+ekān | kurvan nara+dur+ācarān |
varṣāṇi ṣaṭ (śama+Ckarma+)prepsur* | akarot kārśyam ātmanaḥ || 12.95 |

— Buddhacarita, Chapter 12, Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

The verse speaks of Siddhartha's intense ascetic practices. He engaged in numerous forms of fasting and self-mortification, actions that were considered difficult and even harmful by ordinary people. For six long years, driven by a desire for tranquility and liberation from suffering, he relentlessly pursued these practices, causing his body to become emaciated.

Think about the sheer determination this verse reveals. Siddhartha wasn't dabbling in meditation retreats; he was pushing his physical limits, enduring hardship in the belief that it would lead him to enlightenment. The "nara-dur-ācarān" – the difficult practices – highlight the extremity of his efforts. He truly believed that by conquering his physical desires, he could unlock a deeper spiritual truth.

In our modern world, we might not engage in such drastic measures, but the principle resonates. We often seek quick fixes and instant gratification, avoiding discomfort. Siddhartha's example challenges us to confront our own attachments and aversions. Are we willing to endure temporary discomfort for long-term growth? Are we truly committed to our spiritual goals, or do we shy away from the necessary work?

The verse also prompts us to reflect on the nature of true renunciation. Siddhartha eventually realized that extreme asceticism was not the path to enlightenment. It's a reminder that true renunciation isn't about punishing the body, but about detaching from the ego and the cravings that bind us. It's about finding balance and cultivating inner peace, not through self-inflicted pain, but through mindful awareness and compassionate self-acceptance. We can apply this to our own lives by examining our relationship with our bodies and our desires, seeking moderation and wisdom in our pursuits. It's a call to find the middle way.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Are you willing to examine your own "difficult practices" in life, questioning whether they truly serve your spiritual growth or if they are merely a form of self-punishment?